were selected. Chandrasekaran replied that he would ‘make every opportunity count’. Ratan cautioned him about the challenges that would be waiting for the new chairman. He said that he was managing a ‘business that is doing exceedingly well’, but he might have to face many challenges in other sectors, ranging from telecom to steel, if he were to head the group. Ratan therefore advised him to take a thought-out decision.

Happy, but a little daunted by the offer, Chandrasekaran went home deep in thought. He tells me: ‘I do not share any office matter at home. This I told my wife.’ After hearing him out, Lalita, his wife of twenty-two years, impassively told him: ‘You are currently very happy reading this page of the book. You would not know what is coming next unless you turn the page.’ Her words vindicated what he was thinking.

The Marathoner

The selection committee went about its task. It was reportedly considering Indra Nooyi, Ralf Speth, Chandrasekaran, Harish Manwani, Ishaat Hussain, Muthuraman, Arun Sarin and Noel Tata. Some newspapers hinted that Chandrasekaran and Speth were the favourites. The committee met thrice—on 22 November, 9 December and 4 January—and gave its recommendation.

On 12 January 2017, the Tata Sons board approved the appointment of N. Chandrasekaran as chairman. This time, the choice was Ratan’s. He had already paid dearly for leaving it to a selection committee the previous time. The second time, he was determined not to repeat the mistake.

In Tamil, both Natarajan and Chandrasekaran are names for Lord Shiva. Not many expected someone with a Hindu name to rise to the top of the Tata Group, a conglomerate founded by a Parsi ordained as a Navar and one that is overwhelmingly Parsi-owned.

But it did not matter to Ratan that Chandrasekaran would also be the first chairman who would be a non-Parsi, unrelated to the Tata family, the third non-Tata and the first to rise from the ranks of a Tata company employee to the coveted corner office in Bombay House.

The achievement of the lad from Mohanur village in Tamil Nadu who rose from being an intern in TCS to the apex of the group that nearly has a million employees and a turnover of $128 billion in the 2021–22 (larger than the combined GDP of Sri Lanka, Nepal, Maldives, Bhutan and larger